decided to risk it. Minutes after the train started rolling along the sea, a huge wave dashed against it, submerging all the six coaches under water. The death toll was estimated to be somewhere between 115 and 200. The variation in number is because of the many ticketless travellers on board.

The railway line running from Pamban station to Dhanushkodi pier was washed away. When the then Chief Minister of Madras Minjur Kanakasabhapathi Bhaktavatsalam flew over the affected area later in the same week, he said he could barely see the tip of the train's engine that had completely submerged in the sea. Railway officials familiar with the alignment too reiterated the same thing—'Just six inches of the steam engine's smoke stack was all that was visible.' [133]

Fifty years later in 2014, a newspaper managed to track down one of the surviving drivers and this is what he had to say:

> The train had halted at Kambipaadu after a signal failure when I saw the gigantic waves rip the train's engine off the track and drag the bogies into the ocean. I and a few others managed to climb atop a parked goods train and jump into the ocean to rescue a few people. The bogies had been swept into the ocean, but we managed to save a few people who stayed afloat. Even my miraculous escape is an act of God.
>
> —Assistant locomotive pilot K. Nagalingam, who was on the washed-away train. [134]

Along with the train and the railway alignment to Dhanushkodi, a 1¼-mile-long stretch of the historic Pamban rail bridge that linked the Indian mainland to the island of Rameswaram was also badly damaged; 126 of its 145 girders collapsed, though the lift span survived. It was the legendary E. Sreedharan who rebuilt the bridge in a span of 46 days! He was presented the Minister of Railways' Award in 1964 for its completion before the allotted time of six months.

Now officially called the Annai Indira Gandhi bridge, but originally called the Scherzer Rolling Lift bridge (because it was a cantilever bridge) after its American-born designer engineer William Scherzer, or simply the Pamban bridge, it was first built in 1914 by the British for smoother administrative control by bringing provinces, towns, districts and villages in Rameswaram in contact with mainland Tamil Nadu.

SECRETS OF INDIA'S FIRST RAJDHANI